AI Bootcamp — Week 1: Foundations

Wednesday — Student Exercise Guide

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OBJECTIVES

By end of Week 1, the candidate can:

- Explain the Prompt/Harness/Model framework and why the harness, not the model, controls what a skill can do
- Apply the EDD (Evaluation-Driven Development) discipline: write Evaluation Criteria (EC) and manual test cases before building any skill
- Explain and apply the RTCC prompt structure (Role = WHO, Task = WHAT, Context = WHY, Constraints = HOW) to a real skill
- Build four sequential content creation skills as durable, committed `.skill.md` files
- Direct an AI to write a Python evaluation script (deterministic checks plus an LLM judge) and interpret its results
- Verify that every instruction in a skill is load-bearing using manual tests and evaluation runs
- Produce a working end-to-end content pipeline: Trend Identification → Ideation → Development → Graphics

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TIMING

- **Monday:** 1:00 PM – 5:00 PM (travel morning, 4 hours)
- **Tuesday–Thursday:** 9:00 AM – 5:00 PM with 1-hour lunch (7 hours each)
- **Friday:** 9:00 AM – 12:00 PM (travel afternoon, 3 hours)

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WEDNESDAY (9:00 AM – 5:00 PM): IDEATION SKILL

9:00 – 10:00 AM — EDD FIRST: WRITE THE IDEATION TEST FILE

Skill 2: Ideation:

- **Input:** The `trends.md` file from Skill 1 (or a specified trend from it)
- **Output file:** `ideas.md`: a structured list of post ideas for social media, each grounded in one of the identified trends
- **Required output elements:** Post concept (one-line summary), target platform, estimated audience segment, angle or hook, why this trend makes this idea timely now

Write your manual test file before touching the skill. For at least 3 inputs (different trends or trend files), define the EC and at least one explicit failure mode.

10:00 – 11:30 AM — BUILD AND EVALUATE FROM THE START

For the Ideation skill, skip the manual-only phase and bring evaluation in from the first build. Write the RTCC skill, then immediately direct the AI to generate the evaluation script from your EC (deterministic checks first, LLM judge where judgment is required). Run the baseline (Red state), then iterate.

Every change: one hypothesis, one instruction change, one evaluation run.

11:30 AM – 1:00 PM — LUNCH

1:00 – 3:00 PM — REFINEMENT AND THE LOAD-BEARING AUDIT

After at least 3 evaluation iterations on the Ideation skill, perform the load-bearing audit:

- Read each instruction in the skill
- For each: predict which check would fail if you removed it
- If you cannot name a check that would fail, flag the instruction
- Remove flagged instructions and run the evaluation again: confirm the results do not drop

Candidates consistently find instructions that "feel important" but are load-bearing on nothing. This is the refactor step, and the evaluation script makes it mechanical.

3:00 – 5:00 PM — PIPELINE CONNECTION: TREND ID → IDEATION

Run the two-skill pipeline end to end:

1. Run Trend Identification on a topic area → produce `trends.md`
2. Feed `trends.md` as input to Ideation → produce `ideas.md`

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Evaluate the `ideas.md` output against your Ideation EC. Note: some failures may be caused by weak `trends.md` output, not by the Ideation skill itself. Trace failures to their source.

This is the first time candidates encounter **upstream quality dependency**, a concept that recurs throughout the program.

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